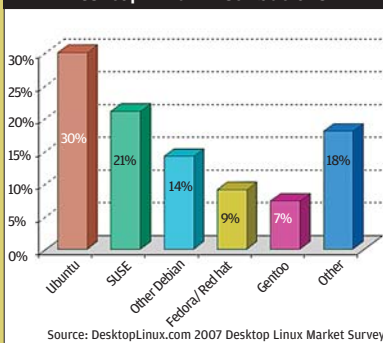




Stat Attack

It's all in the numbers

Desktop Linux Distributions



One cyber-crime is committed every 10 seconds in Britain. Amongst the top categories are the usual suspects: financial fraud, identity theft, hacking into PCs

Sales of HD media stood at 3.7 million by end of July this year.

**Blu-ray: 2.2 mn.
HD-DVD: 1.5 mn.**

Americans' Knowledge Of Online Threats: Only 42% knew they even existed; 17% of those had fallen for Net scams

Internet scams have cost Americans \$7 bn (Rs 29,000 crore) since 2005

Only 40% of PS3 owners knew their console had a Blu-ray player!

device based on a nanowire. The information is stored in the physical structure of the nanowire, and the physical structure is altered by pulses of current between crystalline (not so resistive) and amorphous (highly resistive). That makes for ones and zeroes, which means... storage! These memory gates have read/write times between 50 to 100 ns, which is slower than RAM but not much slower than hard disks.

Then, at the Intel Developer Forum, Pat Gelsinger made a passing reference to a hardware-based disk encryption technology called Danbury: there will be encryption

hardware in the chipset, that will be used to encrypt the drive.

Coming to optical storage, Warner has decided to forget about its Total HD hybrid format. Slated to arrive by early 2008, Total HD offers both Blu-ray and HD-DVD content on a single disc. Yet another attempt to make peace between HD-DVD and Blu-ray has failed.

More on the innovation front: an Israeli start-up called Mempel has built a see-through disc called the TeraDisc which uses fluorescence to store 600 to 700 GB. In a year, they say, it will go up to 1 TB. Here, a red laser writes the disc by focusing on a point, causing

a chemical reaction so that the fluorescent molecules change state (between fluorescent and non-fluorescent.) The disc is read by looking for the presence or absence of fluorescence. Now we're not overly confident about this one, simply because it seems too good to be true—even the drive will cost just about \$3000, it's been reported! Still, keep an eye out.

And finally (coming down to earth from 1 TB!) China has decided—yet again, if you remember EVD—to begin developing its own HD disc format, called CH-DVD. ("CH" for "China"; cheeky.) The format, physically very similar to HD-DVD, could be launched in China by 2008.

Why we're bothered about China is, of course, manufacturing. If CH-DVD is launched, China gets its own HD format—meaning more money for the country because it won't have to pay royalties for manufacturing other formats. But more interestingly, manufacturing for HD-DVD discs could move to China as well, because of the physical similarities. And if that happens, production costs of HD-DVD discs would drop, and HD-DVD would gain in the race vs. Blu-ray.

To sum it up: the cost per GB or TB, whether on disk or disc, could come down at a rate higher than expected; the HD formats are very much battling it out; and China could make HD-DVD cheaper. A lot's happened in the past month.

POVERTY NO BAR

Wiring The Dark Continent

About 5 lakh people across 10 countries in Africa, whom the UN describes as "the poorest of the poor," will soon be connected to the mobile network. The plan is part of the UN Millennium Villages programme. The UN hopes the connections will help improve education and healthcare while boosting local economies. As an example, there can now be emergency telephone numbers.

The infrastructure—and also solar chargers for phones—have been provided for free by Ericsson. Services, though, will be run and charged for by local operators. In most of the countries being catered to, Ericsson will install a 2G network able to handle voice as well as data at around 200 kbps—more than good enough for Internet access.

Ken Banks of Kiwanja.net, an organisation that helps promote innovative uses for mobiles, said the arrival of mobile phones would spur new businesses. As an example: "Taxi drivers will be using mobiles to get business, as will casual labourers."

Africa is, as you might know, the least-connected continent. Less than 2 per cent of the population has

Microsoft SideWinder

It's raining gaming mice. After Logitech's G9, it's now Microsoft's turn—with SideWinder. Now Microsoft did have a line of gaming peripherals—steering wheels, joysticks, and gamepads—called SideWinder, which was discontinued in 2003, but Microsoft has now announced they are restarting it. The first in the line-up will be the SideWinder gaming mouse, to be released in October.

This gamer's companion is *extremely* customisable, and has a totally new feature—an LCD screen. Then, as

you might have come to expect, there are two vertical buttons, adjustable weights for the best grip, and a dented scroll-wheel—all of which will give gamers that extra edge when they are fighting for their, umm, virtual lives. One vertical button, for instance, can be configured so your character can make a 180-degree turn—a definite life-saver in FPS games! The mouse has been called "5,000 mice in one" because with all the hardware and software customisations that can be done, you get nearly 5,000 permutations. The SideWinder will retail at just \$79.95 (Rs 3,300).

Buzzword
of the MONTH